Employee Handbook

Halden · Design studio · Amsterdam & Lisbon · Version 2026.1 · Updated 12 January 2026

Fictional company. This document was written for a portfolio demo — nothing in it is real.

1. Time off

Annual leave

Everyone at Halden gets 27 days of paid annual leave per calendar year, on top of public holidays. Part-time colleagues get the same number of days pro rata.

What changed in 2026

Annual leave went up from 25 to 27 days on 12 January 2026. Carry-over went up from 3 to 5 days.

Public holidays

We follow the public holidays of the country in your contract: the Netherlands for Amsterdam, Portugal for Lisbon. You may swap one public holiday a year for another day that matters to you.

Carry-over

You can carry up to 5 unused days into the next year. Carried-over days must be used by 31 March, after which they expire without payment.

Booking days off

Book time off in the Hours app at least 2 weeks ahead for anything longer than 3 days. Your lead approves within 2 working days. For single days, a day's notice is fine.

Unpaid leave

After one year at Halden you can ask for up to 4 weeks of unpaid leave per year. Talk to your lead first, then People Ops confirms in writing.

2. Remote and hybrid work

Office days

Teams meet in the studio two days a week, Tuesday and Thursday. The other days you choose where you work.

Working from abroad

You can work from another country for up to 30 days per year. Ask People Ops at least 3 weeks before, because some countries need a permit even for short stays.

Core hours

Be reachable between 10:00 and 16:00 in your contract's time zone. Outside core hours, nobody expects a reply.

3. Expenses

Meals when travelling

On a work trip, meals are covered up to €45 per day. Alcohol is not covered, except at client dinners approved by your lead.

Hotels

Book hotels through Travelbase. The nightly cap is €160 in most cities and €220 in London, Paris, New York and Zurich.

Receipts

Upload receipts in the Tally app within 30 days. Expenses without a receipt are not refunded, except taxis under €20.

Getting paid back

Approved expenses are paid with your next salary. Anything above €1,000 needs approval from Finance before you spend it.

4. Equipment

Laptops

You get a laptop on your first day. It is replaced every 3 years, or sooner if it breaks. Personal laptops cannot be used for client work.

Home-office budget

Every new colleague gets a one-off home-office budget of €600 for a chair, desk, screen or lighting. The items are yours to keep.

Lost equipment

Report broken or lost equipment to IT within 24 hours. If you lose a laptop through clear carelessness, Halden may ask you to pay up to €300 towards a new one.

5. Family and health

Parental leave

The birth parent gets 20 weeks of leave at full pay. Partners and adoptive parents get 12 weeks at full pay, to take within the first year.

Calling in sick

Tell your lead before 10:00 on the first day, by message or phone. No reason is needed. From the 4th day in a row, a doctor's note is needed.

Support line

Everyone can use Openwell, a confidential support line with 6 free sessions a year with a counsellor. Halden never sees who uses it.

Sick children

If your child is ill, you can take up to 5 paid care days a year.

6. Learning

Yearly budget

Each person has €1,200 per year for courses, books and conferences. The budget does not roll over to the next year.

Paying back training

If you leave Halden within 12 months after a course that cost more than €1,000, you pay back half of its cost.

7. Joining and leaving

Probation

The first 2 months are a probation period. During probation, either side can end the contract with 1 week's notice.

Notice period

After probation, the notice period is 2 months, for you and for Halden. It starts on the first day of the next month.

Side projects

You may work on side projects outside working hours, as long as they do not compete with a Halden client. Tell your lead before you start.

Questions? People Ops — people@halden.example — #ask-people on Slack.